2 The Stone Age— a Settled Life

Learning Outcomes

The learner:

- identifies the features of the Neolithic Age.
- compares and contrasts Neolithic Age with the Palaeolithic and Mesolithic Ages.
- recognizes how and where farming began.
- identifies the sources that have helped historians learn about life in the Neolithic Age.
- recognizes how farming led to a settled life.
- identifies other changes in the way of life of human beings in the Neolithic Age.
- explains how metals were discovered, leading to changes in the tools and weapons used by human beings in the Chalcolithic Age.

Let's Take-off

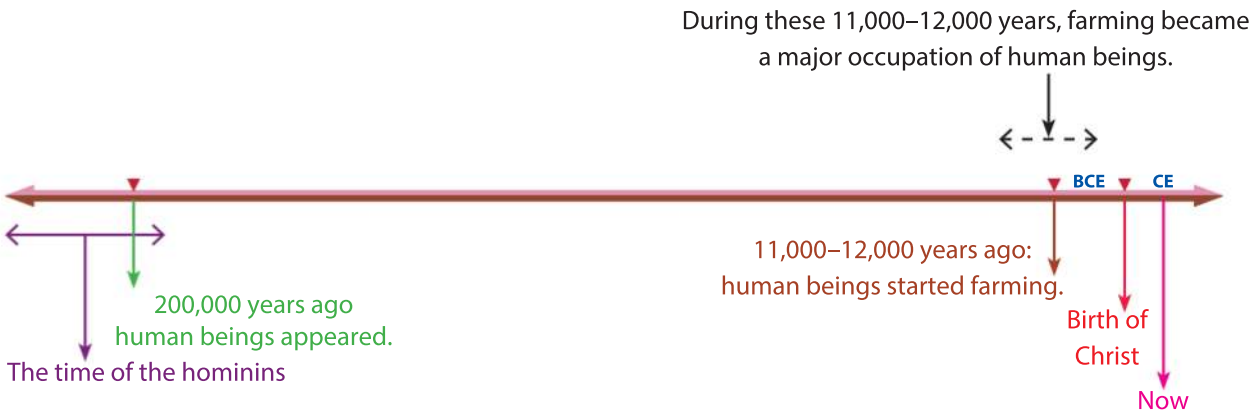
Observation

A common Indian lunch is rice, chapattis made from wheat flour, lentils (dal) and vegetables. Draw red arrows to show how these foods come to us. One has been done for you.

Rice:	Farmer →	**Wholesaler** →	Shopkeeper →	Customer
Wheat:	Farmer	Wholesaler	Shopkeeper	Customer
Lentils:	Farmer	Wholesaler	Shopkeeper	Customer
Vegetables:	Farmer	Wholesaler	Shopkeeper	Customer

- In each case, who is the actual producer of the food? C-1.2

You buy the things you eat from a shopkeeper or store. They buy these from a wholesaler who buys things in very large quantities from farmers. He sells these to shopkeepers or stores. It is the farmers who grow almost all the food we eat. Experts think that farming started many thousands of years after human beings first appeared on earth. The timeline on the next page shows you this.

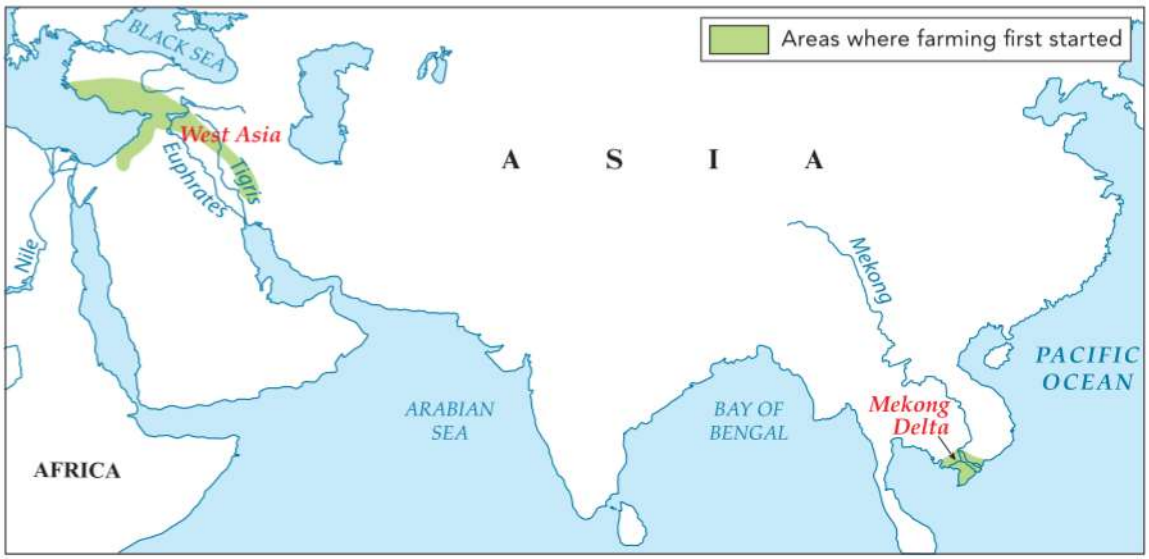


THE NEW STONE AGE

The Beginning of Farming

(Left) Wild wheat plants that have few and small seeds; (right) Wheat plants cultivated by farmers that have more and bigger seeds. Early farmers learnt to produce such **cereals**. More food became available from each plant.

As the hunter-gatherers wandered about in search of food, they probably noticed that many plants, such as wild wheat, had **seeds** that could be eaten. They also saw that if these seeds fell on the ground, sometime later new plants of the same kind began to grow there. They realized that they could gather such seeds and plant them near where they lived. Seeds from one or two plants would give them many plants and food for many people. This was a big **discovery**. It was the start of farming. Hunter-gatherers had to search for food and eat whatever was available—they were dependent on the environment. Now human beings could plant the food they wanted to eat—they were making changes in the environment. Slowly people changed from hunting-gathering to farming. This did not happen at the same time all over the world.



Farming first started in West Asia. Later, it started in South-east Asia in the region of the Mekong Delta. Find these places in the map.

Did You Know?

The part of West Asia, where farming first started is called the 'Fertile Crescent'. The land was very fertile and crops grew easily. This area is mostly desert now. Find out what `crescent' means and look again at the map.

TP Sources

Archaeologists have found several different sources from which they have been able to guess what the lives of the early farmers were like. They have found grinding stones for grinding seeds into flour, tools used for farming and pots for cooking or storage. They have also found the remains of villages which tell them that the lives of the people became more settled as farmers had to look after their crops.

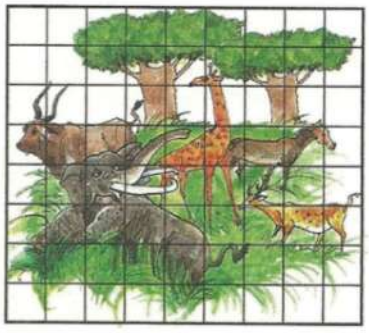
A grinding stone from the New Stone Age—cereal grains were ground into flour on the bigger stone using a smaller stone.

Farming Changed People's Lives

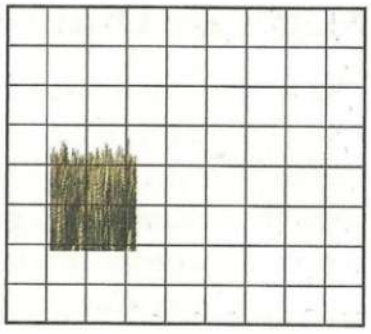
Farming was a very important development in human history. It changed the way that human beings had lived for thousands of years. These are the ways in which the lives of people changed:

Life became more settled

Hunter-gatherers had to wander over a large area to hunt animals or gather food for a group of people (drawing 1). With farming, crops that provided food for the same number of people could be grown in a much smaller area (drawing 2).



Drawing 1



Drawing 2

After studying sources, experts think that early villages may have looked like this.

People lived near their crops to be able to care for them.

Small villages grew

People's lives became more settled. The first huts were made of blocks of clay which had been dried in the sun. Many of these villages grew into towns and cities later.

Domestication of Animals

Dogs were the first animals to be **domesticated**. They were domesticated while human beings were still hunter-gatherers. Dogs were useful as guard animals and hunting companions. Later sheep, goats and cows were domesticated and provided milk, meat, wool and skin.

Discuss Communication

Dogs were useful to early human beings. Talk about the way that dogs are part of the lives of human beings these days. C-1.2

The food of the people changed

Hunter-gatherers ate mostly meat and fish as well as fruits, roots and seeds. After they started farming, people ate mainly cereals, some vegetables, meat and drank milk.

Some Stone Age pots were decorated.

Many other things became possible

As a result of farming, enough food for the entire village could be grown by just a few people. Other people in the group had time to think about and do other things. For example, some people learnt to make clay pottery. The pots could be used for cooking or storing food.

Did You Know?

Archaeologists have found images of mother-goddesses in several parts of the world. They think that early farmers worshipped the earth as a mother who helped them produce their food.

Trade developed

Villages and towns produced more food and other goods than they needed. They began to exchange the extra goods with each other. This was the start of **trade**, which is the buying and selling of goods.

HOTS Critical Thinking

Why do you think that farming is a major occupation all over the world? C-6.1

The population began to grow

Over hundreds of years, early farmers grew better and more crops, so gradually food became more easily available. The number of people increased.

Knowledge of India

One of the earliest examples of farming in the Indian subcontinent is from Mehrgarh (near Balochistan), from the late Neolithic period. Some primitive varieties of wheat and barley have been found here.

Herding

All animals and plants that we use, were at one time, found only in the wild. Some places were not suitable for growing crops. Here, people kept herds of domesticated animals like sheep, goats or cattle that ate wild grasses and plants. When the food for their animals was finished

in one place, people moved to another where it was available. These people were wandering herders. In many places, including in India, people lead similar lives even today.

METAL AGE

Some copper tools

The Stone Age was followed by the Metal Age, when people discovered how to use metals. The earliest part of this period is the Chalcolithic Age or Copper Age when copper, the red **metal**, was discovered and used. Though people continued to use stone tools, copper was also used to make tools. However, copper is a soft metal, and the tools needed to be sharpened often.

Later another metal, tin, was discovered in some parts of the world. This was mixed with copper to make **bronze**. This is stronger than copper. This period, in which bronze became the most commonly used metal, is called the Bronze Age. Many artefacts from the Bronze Age have been discovered, such as tools, cooking vessels, weapons, jewellery and decorative items.

Copper and bronze are used even today to make jewellery, statues, utensils and medals. Much later, iron was discovered, about which you will read in the next chapter.

Think and Answer

Critical Thinking

Which discoveries of early human beings do we still use today? C-6.1

This table will help you to understand these different parts of the Metal Age.

The age of metals	Types of objects made
Chalcolithic or Copper Age	Precious things like jewellery, some tools
Bronze Age	Tools, cooking vessels, weapons, jewellery
Iron Age	Tools, weapons, cooking pots, nails, coins

Did You Know?

Gold is considered the most precious metal because its colour never changes. The oldest gold artefacts found still have a lovely golden glow.

A Better World

Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs)

Goal 11: Sustainable Cities and Communities

With the development of farming, as life became more settled, people took up different occupations—some were farmers, whereas others looked after animals, made pottery, traded surplus goods and so on. Do you think this is a good example of a sustainable community? C-1.2

FARMING IN INDIA

Farming started very early in the Indian subcontinent. Even today, most Indians live in villages where the main occupation is farming. In some places the methods of farming have not changed for centuries, but in others farming with tractors and modern tools is also practised.

An Indian farmer—his hoe (the farming tool in the picture) has a metal blade and wooden handle.

Values and Life Skills

- Early human beings lived in a very different world to ours. If we remember what that time was like and in how many ways their lives changed, it will help us to understand them.
- You can try to imagine how other people live. Read about them to learn more and understand them better.

REMEMBER

The Stone Age—a Settled Life

- Farming was a major development in human history.
- Farming changed human lives.
- Some people were wandering herders.
- Metals were discovered during this time.
- Farming started early in the Indian subcontinent. Millions of Indians are still farmers.

NEW WORDS

Wholesaler	a person who buys foods in large quantities from farmers to sell to shopkeepers
Cereals	plants such as rice and wheat, whose seeds or grains are eaten
Discovery	finding or learning something for the first time
Domesticate	to tame animals or grow plants for human use
Trade	the activity of buying and selling or of exchanging goods
Metal	material such as iron, gold, silver or copper, which is usually hard and shiny
Bronze	a metal made by mixing copper and tin

EXERCISES

A. Choose the correct answers. More than one answer may be correct.

1. People learnt to grow cereals that provided enough food for a small number of people/ more food per plant/a small amount of food per plant.
2. Farming happened where it was possible to grow good crops/at the same time in different places /at different times all over the world.
3. We have no sources/several sources/very few sources that tell us about early farming.
4. Pots were used as decorative pieces/used for cooking or storing food/made of clay.
5. Herds of animals belonging to wandering herders were fed cultivated crops/ate wild grasses and plants/cooked food.
6. Read the statements below and choose the correct option.

   Statement (A): Bronze was made by mixing tin and copper.

   Statement (B): Bronze was a stronger metal than copper.

   (a) Both A and B are true, and B is the correct explanation of A.

   (b) Both A and B are true, but B is not the correct explanation of A.

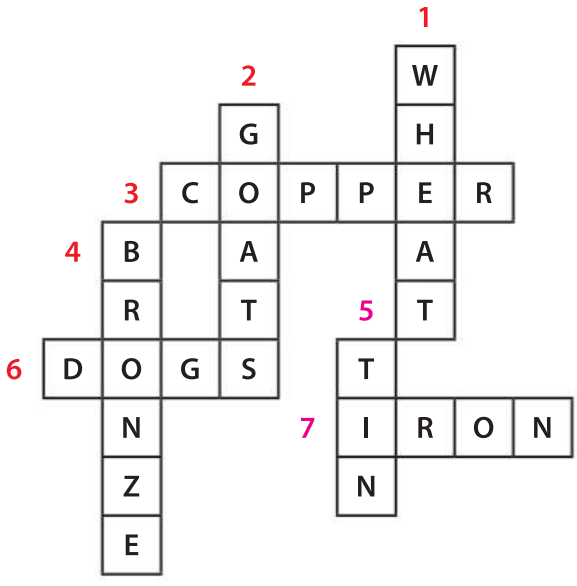
   (c) A is true but B is false.

   (d) A is false but B is true.

B. Write true or false. Correct the false sentences in your notebook.

1. Farming started about 20,000 years ago.
2. The seeds of wild cereals were the same size as the seeds of cultivated cereals.
3. Farming first started in West Asia.
4. Herders moved to a new place when the grass and plants to feed their animals were finished.
5. Copper is a hard metal.

C. Write the clues for this crossword in your notebook.



D. Fill in the blanks.

Copy the table in your notebook. Fill the blanks to see how the lives of people changed with the coming of farming.

	Hunter-gatherers	Farmers
Lifestyle		Settled
Food		
Homes		
Number of people	Few	
Art and craft		Pots made of clay
Tools made of		First stone, then metal
The group	Everyone helped to find food	

E. Answer the following questions.

1. Explain one main difference in the way in which hunter-gatherers and farmers lived with their environment.
2. What is the difference between wild and cultivated cereals? How is this useful for us?
3. Why was farming a major development in human history?
4. List the ways in which people's lives changed once farming started. Explain any two of these.
5. Who were wandering herders? Why did they need to wander?
6. Write a short paragraph about the Copper and Bronze Ages. Use these words: tin, tools, weapons, strong.

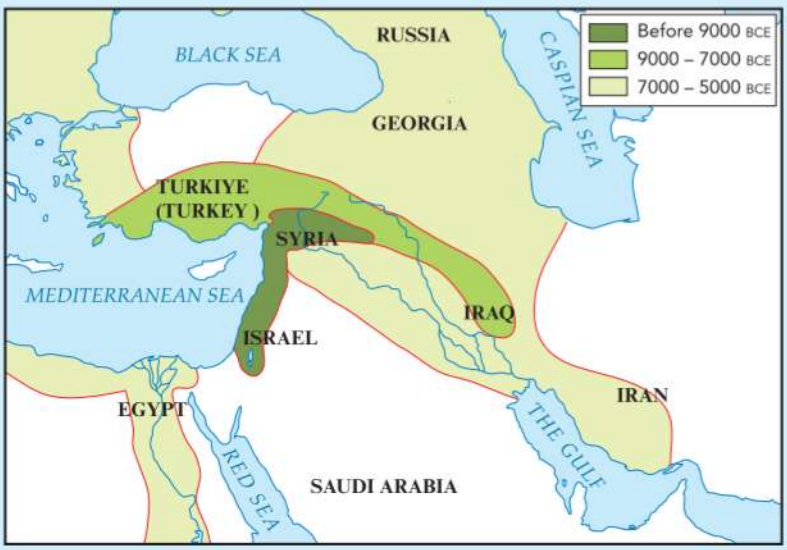
DO AND LEARN

A. Picture Study

Study the map and find out the following:

1. Two places where farming started before 9000 BCE
2. Two places where farming spread between 9000–7000 BCE
3. The places where farming spread between 7000–5000 BCE

C-5.3 Map reading



B. On Your Own

Use your imagination: Try to imagine the lives of hunter-gatherers and of early farmers. Which of these would you have liked to live as? Write two sentences, beginning: 'I would have liked to live as a ..... because ..... Creativity

TP

C. In a Group

Imagine the past: Early farming communities probably cooked over an open fire, surrounded by stones to prevent the fire from spreading. They did not have oil, spices or sugar, but they could grind the seeds of the cereals. They also had bowls. Talk about the things they might have cooked with their cereals, milk and meat. You can also do a short skit for your classmates.

C-6.2 Collaboration SI Theatre

D. Pair and Share:

Discuss with your partner which food that we eat today is not produced by farmers. C-6.1 Communication

Weblink For more information, go to:

Neolithic Times—Five things you should know:

- https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=WBrkYxf4798 (Accessed on 31 July 2025)

What I Learnt

Self-review

Colour the smileys to show how well you have understood the concepts.	Completely	Mostly	Need help
• I can identify the features of the Neolithic Age.	☺	☺	☺
• I can compare and contrast the Neolithic Age with the Palaeolithic and Mesolithic Ages.	☺	☺	☺
• I can recognize how and where farming began.	☺	☺	☺
• I can identify the sources that have helped historians learn about life in the Neolithic Age	☺	☺	☺
• I can recognize how farming led to a settled life.	☺	☺	☺
• I can identify other changes in the way of life of human beings in the Neolithic Age.	☺	☺	☺
• I can explain how metals were discovered, leading to changes in the tools and weapons used by human beings in the Chalcolithic Age.	☺	☺	☺